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Language problem or language conflict? Narratives of immigrant women's experiences in the US

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Abstract

This article investigates how Latin American women who migrate to the US frame their language experiences through narratives told in sociolinguistic interviews. As narratives reflect and shape social realities and relationships, narrative analysis can illuminate how individuals position themselves relative to language obstacles and ideologies, thus providing insights into processes that are central to the migration experiences of millions of individuals. We found that women related two types of stories: *language conflict narratives*, in which language was presented as part of a broader ethnic or social conflict, and *language difficulty narratives*, which focused on individual, personal problems with language experienced by protagonists. Our analysis illustrates how interviewers' questions, and the interviewees' language conflict narratives in particular, confirm, reproduce, but also contest central language ideologies and dominant discourses about migration in the US.

Keywords

argument, conflict, English, Hispanic, immigrant, language ideology, Latino, narrative, positioning, Spanish, women

1. Introduction

Millions of economic (im)migrants enter the United States each year, the majority of whom are Spanish-speakers from Latin American countries. Roughly 10 million

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documented immigrants settled in the US between 1991 and 2000 (US Census, 2003), and by 2008 an additional 12 million undocumented immigrants resided in the country, of whom three-quarters were Latino (Passel and Cohn, 2009). This most recent group of Latino migrants includes more women than in the past, and also individuals with a more diverse set of literacy, education, and employment skills (Hellman, 2006; Menard-Warwick, 2009). Nevertheless, Latino (im)migrants in the US – as in many countries – are disproportionately employed in low-status, low-wage, and low-skilled sectors such as food preparation and cleaning services (Pew Hispanic, 2008). One of the most significant challenges these individuals face is lack of English proficiency. Indeed, limited English skills present a substantial obstacle in negotiating employment as well as services such as health care and education (Martinez, 2008; Warriner, 2007). This practical difficulty is exacerbated by the strong ideologies tied to both English and Spanish within broader debates and discourses on US immigration (Linton, 2009).

Investigating how people make sense of these language difficulties as well as these strong ideological currents is a central task for discourse analysts interested in migration. To this end, the present article investigates how Latin American women migrants to the US frame their language experiences within sociolinguistic interviews. We focus on narratives as this discursive genre constitutes a significant means through which individuals construct life experiences and position identities. As narratives reflect and shape social realities and relationships (Baynham, 2003; De Fina et al., 2006; Maryns and Blommaert, 2001; Wortham, 2001), we argue that narrative analysis provides insights into processes that are central to the migration experience of millions of individuals.

1.1. Immigrants in the linguistic market

Sociolinguistics and social theorists often have pointed to the status of languages as goods both in local and global markets (e.g. Heller, 2007; Sarangi, 2001), noting that their perceived social value is determined by prestige and power rather than utility. This understanding is informed by Bourdieu's (1986) conception of the social world as consisting of relations involving power and defined by struggles over varied resources. These resources are not simply economic, but also cultural and symbolic. While *economic* capital is accrued through money and assets and *social* capital through relations and influences, *cultural* capital entails the accumulation of knowledge and the right of access to the tools for acquiring that knowledge. All three resources can become *symbolic* power, 'which is the form that the various species of capital assume when they are perceived as legitimate' (Bourdieu, 1989: 17). Thus, through the accumulation of symbolic power, individuals and groups acquire positions of privilege, and, in turn, social differences are legitimated.

Language is an important form of cultural capital given that it has the potential to be transformed into symbolic capital and therefore into a tool for individuals and communities to ensure better social positions. These insights are crucial in analyzing the cultural and material processes of migration as immigrants' lives are profoundly influenced by the symbolic status of their native and new languages. Such symbolic status is established through social and discursive practices that attach certain values to languages and language users; these practices also serve as vehicles for the construction and circulation of language ideologies. As Van Dijk (1998) notes, *ideologies* are shared social beliefs and

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representations that underlie social practices and discourses. In turn, *language ideologies* 'are ideas about language circulating in various discourses' (Collins and Slembrouck, 2005: 189). These include evaluations of linguistic structures or forms as 'good' or 'bad', as well as language-based evaluations of individuals as 'smart', 'lazy', or 'criminal' (Collins and Slembrouck, 2005).

Language ideologies are central to public discourses about migration in the US in part because such discourses have long linked English acquisition with social acceptance into the national community. As Pavlenko (2002) documents, the rise and solidification of intolerant attitudes towards the presence of other languages coincided with the great migration wave of 1880–1924. During this period, 'monolingualism came to signify ''Americanness''' (2002: 164), and concomitantly, xenophobia and fear of immigration-related changes became widespread. More recently, in the face of shifting immigration patterns, the Spanish language has become a focus of political discourse and activism (MacGregor-Mendoza, 1998). For instance, recent news (Goldstein, 2009) of a Texas policeman ticketing a woman for not speaking English confirms both the existence and the concrete social consequences of these attitudes.

English competency and English monolingualism in particular, are often taken as proxies for immigrant integration and success (García, 1995; Linton, 2009). Together, such ideologies present considerable challenges to Spanish language use and maintenance (Urciuoli, 1996; Zentella, 1997). Data suggest that decades after the Civil Rights movement, the US can still be described as a cemetery for non-English languages. For instance, while Spanish remains the second most widely spoken language in the US,[1] data indicate that Latino immigrants – and their children, in particular – are quickly transitioning to English monolingualism (e.g. Rumbaut et al., 2006).

Nevertheless, immigration and language remain highly charged political and policy issues. The last decade alone saw 10 states adopt English-only education initiatives and no fewer than 20 separate pieces of federal legislation promoting English as the national or official language of the US (US English, 2010). Recent months have also seen controversial, anti-immigrant legislation such as SB1070, passed in Arizona in April 2010, which requires that police ascertain immigration status when there is 'reasonable suspicion that the person . . . is unlawfully present in the U.S.' (State of Arizona, 2010). While what might make one 'reasonably' suspect is not legislated, one could reasonably assume that speaking Spanish would be sufficient.

Together, these discourses and social practices are tightly linked to a set of ideologies that equate speaking English and being a good citizen, that demonize Spanish, and that, furthermore, attribute responsibility for learning English to immigrants themselves (Haviland, 2003). While competence in Spanish is increasingly valuable cultural capital for US elites (King, 2009; Pomerantz, 2002), Spanish competence very often presents a real and ideological problem for immigrants, as it is associated with lack of English competence, failure to assimilate, and illegality.

1.2. Narratives as a site for the negotiation of social reality

Within this dynamic and highly politicized context in which English and Spanish occupy center stage in the lives of Latin American immigrants, we investigated how women presented language experiences within sociolinguistic interviews. We focus on narrative

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as a site for studying the construction of language experience. Because of narratives' capacity to vividly evoke the concrete story worlds in which interactions are re-lived by new audiences, this discourse genre has a special position within the study of social practices (Fairclough, 1992) and within discourse practices in particular.

Edwards and Potter (1992), investigating fact reconstruction in narratives, noted that narratives have a special power in granting credibility to narrators and for this reason people often embed stories into accounts. Indeed, narratives also function as 'eyewitness testimonials' (Müller and Di Luzio, 1995) and are thus more believable than open arguments. However, narrative discourse is also a form of argumentation, allowing narrators to express opinions and beliefs indirectly, through the mediation of characters. As evident below, since stories present worlds removed from the immediate interaction which in some sense 'belong' to the narrators, the tellers can readily use them to back up claims and opinions (Schiffrin, 1990). For these reasons, narrative discourse provides a privileged site for the negotiation of social reality. Further, stories are particularly productive sites of analysis for the study of immigrant perceptions and experiences as they reflect and build on shared ideologies and all kinds of shared presuppositions, while also (re)shaping understandings through compliance or resistance with mainstream values and discourses (Baynham and De Fina, 2005; De Fina, 2006). Applying these insights to narratives of language experience, we focus here on how narrators and interviewers both reproduce and contest widely circulating ideologies about languages and their users.

2. The data and study approach

The data for the present analysis are derived from a project investigating language experiences and perceptions of language policy among Latin American women in the greater Washington, DC area (King and De Fina, 2010). While the number of foreign-born immigrants in Washington is relatively low in absolute terms (only 51,000), DC ranked first in the US in terms of the percentage of foreign-born Hispanics (with neighboring Maryland at two and adjacent Virginia at eight) (Pew Hispanic, 2010a). For this study, we focused on a group that thus far has received little academic attention: Latin American (im)migrant women who have contingent legal status, often no US legal documentation at all, and typically limited contact with English speakers. As such, these women are among the most marginalized US workers (Hondagneu-Sotelo, 2001), with little job security, few to no legal recourses, and minimal institutional or governmental support (Vellos, 1997).

We chose to interview women for several reasons. First, recent migration studies, in particular those focusing on Latin American (im)migrants, have stressed the important role that these women play in the key migration decisions (Miles, 2003) and their critical functions with respect to transactions at stores, schools, and workplaces (Hondagneu-Sotelo, 2001). Second, women have been found to strongly impact processes of linguistic shift and maintenance (e.g. Gal, 1978; Holmes, 1993; Winter and Pauwels, 2005). Yet despite women's central role in these domains, with limited exceptions (Menard-Warwick, 2009; Relaño Pastor and De Fina, 2005) there has been little exploration of their language ideologies and language-related experiences.

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The 15 study participants, who represented a wide geographic swath, hailing from Mexico (two), Bolivia (three), Colombia (two), El Salvador (five), Chile (one), Ecuador (one), and Peru (one), were all foreign-born women. Their ages ranged from 28 to 55 years, with most in their 40s. All had lived in the US for at least four years, with some moving back and forth several times between the US and their home country. Most of the women worked in private domestic spheres, cleaning houses or minding children, and had restricted opportunities for formal schooling in the US, although many had intermittently attended weekly English as a second language or Spanish language literacy classes. The interviewees had varied degrees of competence in English and mostly did not use it in their jobs. We approached the interviewees through personal contacts, which led to snowball sampling. Interviews, which took place in private homes or at public cafés, dealt with the reasons for migrating, experiences with using and learning English, perceptions about the role of Spanish and English in different domains of life, and language policies at a local or national level.

Interviews are unique social encounters (Briggs, 1986; Cicourel, 1964). They constitute occasions in which people make sense of their experiences by building upon common ground and shared understandings. In that respect, they can be seen as sites for re-elaboration of the ideologies and of common-sense understandings (Wortham, forthcoming) that inform the local interaction between participants. In addition, they are theatres for the negotiation of local positionings by participants vis-a-vis each other and the topics discussed. Within interviews, stories are especially powerful sites for the construction of identity, the representation of social relationships, and the negotiation of the moral order (Baynham, 2003; Bucholtz, 1999; De Fina, 2003; Georgakopoulou, 2007; Schiffrin, 1996). The exchanges between participants and the narratives that the women tell in these interviews often presuppose, evoke, and implicate legal and social processes and practices relevant to the material life of immigrants, as well as discourses and ideologies about migration and language. These discourses in turn impact the local construction of identities (e.g. through categorization processes; Sacks, 1966/1992) since interviewers and interviewees engage with circulating notions of what it means to be a Latina, a domestic worker, or, alternatively, a researcher and adjust to each other, negotiating the self-images they wish to project.

Our premise is that close examination of how interactants negotiate and elaborate upon these understandings through storytelling and of how stories emerge within sequences of talk can yield deeper understanding of people's sense-making about social issues. Indeed, we underscore that narratives cannot be seen as isolated texts (Talmy, 2010), but are sequentially produced within the interview and often embedded in argumentative sequences and responses to interview questions. Our analysis therefore specifies how narratives emerged in the interview, the ways in which they are related to arguments made by speakers, and the manner in which narrative topics and the stances conveyed through them were co-constructed by the interviewers and interviewees.

The data here consist of 13 narratives of language conflict. These were told by participants to back up opinions produced by the interviewees, to relate experiences spontaneously, or to respond to direct questions by the interviewers. *Language conflict narratives* were defined as those with one of three types of complicating events at the center of the story-world action:

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a) Antagonist(s) uses lack of competence in English or Spanish as a basis to carry out verbal or non-verbal aggression towards the protagonist or to humiliate her;
b) Antagonist(s) mentions lack of competence in English as a basis to carry out verbal or non-verbal aggression towards the protagonist or to humiliate her;
c) Antagonist(s) ignores the lack of competence in English to carry our verbal or non-verbal aggressions towards the protagonist or to humiliate her.

Not all narratives of language experience were conflict stories. Twelve narratives, classified as *language difficulty narratives*, focused on problems that protagonists experienced due to their lack of English competence. These language difficulties were not constructed as the source of confrontation, but rather as the basis of reflection on lessons learned or as examples of challenges experienced by the protagonist in the US.

Crucially, one aspect that characterizes the majority of language conflict narratives (10 of 13) and that differentiates them from language difficulty narratives is the categorization (within the narrative, mostly in orientation clauses) of antagonists or protagonists (or both) as members of a national, ethnic, or racial group rather than as individuals. Further, this framing of the language problem as involving group conflict was not exclusively proposed by the narrators, but was often co-constructed with the interviewers.

Below, we focus on the type of discourse sequence in which the narratives are embedded and on the narratives' argumentative structure and value. We also highlight the strategies and devices used by narrators to position themselves vis-a-vis the characters in the narratives and the interlocutors in the story-telling world, as well as those used by the interviewers in the interaction. As will be evident, the analysis of argumentative structures – both within the discourse and within the story world – and of the positioning devices is crucial for understanding how narrators and interlocutors construct specific world views and how they try to influence each other's representations of social situations and categories and each other's identity perceptions. Thus, prior to analyzing our examples, we outline the relationships between narratives and arguments and then turn to the notion of positioning.

The study of argumentation traditionally has been the realm of philosophers and logicians with arguments seen as logical operations connecting premises to conclusions. However, rhetoric-oriented scholars interested in everyday arguments note that argumentation as a formal type of reasoning substantially differs from everyday arguments that develop through natural interaction (Antaki, 1994). Nevertheless, both traditional logical and rhetorical approaches to reasoning have a normative focus in that scholars attempt to identify the underlying principles of well-formed arguments (Fisher, 1988). In studies of classical rhetoric, in contrast, arguments are classified into types and related to the operation of specific connectors indicating cause, consequence, and other kinds of logical operations. For this reason, the tools developed within formal or classical approaches to reasoning are ill suited to study naturally occurring arguments.

Rhetoricians (e.g. Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca, 1969; Toulmin et al., 1979) also have noted that everyday arguments are much less structured and context-independent than logical formulae. Indeed, interlocutors develop their reasoning in dialogic fashion and in relation to specific interlocutors and situations; thus, there is an emergent quality to everyday argument that is missing from its more formal or classical counterparts. As

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suggested above, narratives have been found to be an important tool for the development of arguments (Carranza, 1999; De Fina, 2000; Günthner, 1995; Schiffrin, 1990; Van Dijk, 1993). At the most basic level, narratives can function as 'exempla' (Martin and Plum, 1997); that is, they serve as evidence for claims (Günthner, 1995). As noted previously, these 'eyewitness testimonials' (Müller and Di Luzio, 1995) are difficult to challenge and thus rhetorically potent. Narratives can also function as explanations for particular propositions. Yet narratives also potentially contain story-world arguments that might or might not contribute to a general thesis (Carranza, 1999). As noted by Carranza (1999: 519), 'reasonings are also found in local argumentation by characters in the story-world leading to a proposition that is not the general story thesis' so that in the analysis of narratives it is possible to find the use by characters of forms of reasoning such as 'analogy and explanation with a global scope, and on the other hand, the use of logical consequence with local scope'. And indeed, as we will show below, the first narrative is inserted in an argumentative sequence and also functions as *exemplum*, while in the second narrative, argumentative reasoning is used by characters in the story-world in order to make sense of events and to advance the narrator's interpretation of them.

The second important notion that we draw from for narrative analysis here is the construct of positioning, first introduced by Davies and Harré (1990) and subsequently developed by Bamberg (1997) and Wortham (2001). Positioning can be conceived of as the way narrators interactionally manage their identity through storytelling. According to Bamberg and Georgakopoulou (2008), identities result from the interplay of three levels: the first level explores positioning in the story-world, that is, it examines how the narrator as character is positioned vis-a-vis other characters in the world of the story; the second level involves the interactional process, that is, the ways in which the narrator negotiates himself vis-a-vis his interlocutors; the third level addresses how the teller 'positions a sense of self/identity with regards to dominant discourses or master narratives' (p. 385) and how s/he makes them relevant to the interaction.

Scholars such as Wortham (2001) have proposed that certain linguistic structures (e.g. indexicals) and strategies (e.g. reported speech) function as such positioning cues and we therefore point to those elements in the stories. In addition, we also illustrate how argumentative strategies centrally contribute to positioning.

For the analysis of the function of specific utterances produced by narrators within the story we use the categories proposed by Labov (1972). The categories used are the following:

Abstract: presents the gist of the narrative
Orientation: presents details on time, persons, and places
Complicating action: presents conflicts between characters and subsequent actions
Coda: a closing utterance that relates past events to the present establishing connections between past and present, for example consequences
Evaluation: presents the point of view of the narrator about the events

We also added the category 'Complicating event', which represents the main complication in a story.

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3. The stories and analysis

Here we analyze two language conflict narratives, both of which frame ethnic conflict as the source of linguistic conflict. The first narrative (Excerpt 1) was told by Katia, one of two participants who arrived to the US at school age and who did not work as a domestic employee, but as an office clerk. In the turns prior to the excerpt here, the interviewer had been inquiring about Katia's arrival and early experiences in the US. The excerpt begins with Katia responding to questions about how she had dealt initially with her lack of English at school. Katia had answered that she had school counselors, but they did not speak Spanish. We reproduce below the sequence starting from that point:

Excerpt 1

1	Katia:	yo pienso que ellos ((school administrators)) se habían equivocado.
2		y no hablaban nada.
3		pero era difícil después, eh el grupo de amigos también,
4		influyó que el aprendizaje de mi inglés fuera un poco mas lento?
5	Anna:	por qué?
6	Katia:	porque como tampoco hablaba el idioma y la escuela donde yo estaba era
7		era una escuela bastante diversa,
8		y este veía bastante la diferencia en grupos como (.)
9		los blancos tenían su grupito blanco de niños blancos,
10		los morenitos tenían, los afro americanos tenían su grupo y los latinos
11		eran-
12		no nunca veía era muy raro ver mezclados que grupos se reunieran diferentes,
13		de diferentes razas o sea (.)
14		los asiáticos sí se unían mucho con los los niños anglosajones,
15		pero los latinos y los afro americanos eran grupos totalmente diferentes
16		y los veía uno en la cafetería,
17		en el recreo,
18		entonces me sentía más identificada con los niños latinos que acababan de
19		venir de los diferentes países,
20		y sólo hablábamos español,
21		entonces eso como que hizo un poco lento el aprendizaje en inglés.
22	Anna:	y los demás hablaban inglés o su idioma los asiáticos o-?
23	Katia:	hablaban inglés los asiáticos hablaban inglés.
24	Anna:	ah, todos?
25	Katia:	hablaban inglés, si.
26	Anna:	y como era esta relación entre estos grupos, no había ninguna?
27	Katia:	no había ningún tipo.
28		y eso era una de las cosas que hacía sentirme extraña->
29		porque no había como decirte como::, digamos
30		como cuando veían uno que es latino o (.)
31		no sé se sentía como un poco de discriminación,
32		en un principio,
33		o tal vez no discriminación pero veía bastante la diferencia, [entre,

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34 Anna: [en qué sentido?
35 Katia: entre los grupos.
36 en que tal vez uno quería tener amigos blancos pero ellos tampoco era muy
37 amigables->
38 como que había límites hasta donde llegar pero nunca (.) pude tener una
39 amistad con otro,
40 al menos no cuando acababa de llegar.
41 Anna: tu te acuerdas de algo en ese periodo alguna cosa específica que te haya
42 pasado?
43 Katia: oh si, si me @->
44 la primera palabra que que yo aprendí acá era stink,
45 Anna: stink.
46 Katia: porque una una niña una nina de- afro americana estábamos en el baño
47 y yo estaba lavándome las manos y estaba sola,
48 y sí me agredieron y me dijeron "You stink",
49 y entonces yo me quedé con eso en la en la en la mente,
50 y cuando yo le fui a preguntarle a una amiga que hablaba un poquito más de
51 inglés,
52 y me dijo "oh eso quiere decir que tienes mal olor que tu que tu hiedes o algo
53 así",
54 entonces eso@ fue la primera palabra que yo aprendí,
55 entonces ya una empieza a intimidarse más también,
56 porque prácticamente yo no les estaba hacienda nada, y
57 y sí escuchaba historias de varias compañeras mías.
58 e incluso mi hermana,
59 la atacaron unas niñas afro americanas en el baño de la escuela también,
60 la atacaron la golpearon.
61 y la dejaron allí.
62 mi hermana tambien para ese tiempo acababa de venir.
63 tenia 11 meses de haber llegado.
64 Anna: y que paso por que la-
65 Katia: sin razón.
66 simplemente por el hecho de ser latina creo yo

(Story follows)

English translation

1 Katia: I think that they ((the school administrators)) had made a mistake
2 and they didn't speak ((Spanish)) at all
3 but it was very hard and then, uh the group of friends as well,
4 had an impact on the fact that my learning of English was a little slower?
5 Anna: why?
6 Katia: because since I did not speak the language and the school where I was
7 was a school with a lot of diversity,
8 and I could see clearly the differences in groups like (.)
9 the whites had their white group of white kids,

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the blacks had, the African Americans had their group and the Latinos
were-
no I never saw it was very rare to see mixing that groups met of different
from different races that is (.)
Asians did get together quite a lot with Anglo-Saxon kids,
but Latinos and African Americans were totally different groups
and one saw this in the cafeteria,
at lunch break,
then I felt more identified with the Latino kids that had just arrived from the
different countries,
and we only spoke Spanish,
then that is why this made my learning English a little slow.
Anna: and the others spoke English or their language Asians or-?
Katia: Asians spoke English. they spoke English.
Anna: uhu, all?
Katia: yes they spoke English.
Anna: and how was the relation between these groups? there was none?
Katia: no there wasn't any kind.
and that was one of the things that made me feel strange->
because there was no how shall I say, how::, like let's say
when they saw that one was Latino or (.)
I don't know one felt like a little bit of discrimination,
at the beginning,
or may be not discrimination but I clearly saw the difference, [among
Anna: [in what sense?
Katia: among the groups.
in the sense that maybe one wanted to have white friends but they were not
very friendly either->
like there were limits to where one could get to but I never (.) could make
friends with someone else,
at least not when I got here.
Anna: do you remember something of this period something in particular that
happened to you?
Katia: oh yes, yes me@->
the first word that I learned here was stink, ((in English in the text)).
Anna: stink.
Katia: because a girl a girl from- African American we were in the bathroom
and I was washing my hands and was alone,
and they harassed me and they told me "You stink",
and so I stayed with this in in in my mind,
and when I went to ask a friend who spoke a little more
English,
and she said to me "oh this means that you have a bad smell that you smell
bad or something like that",
so that@ was the first word that I learned,

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55 so one starts to get intimidated as well,
56 because practically I wasn't doing anything to her,
57 and I did hear stories from other girl friends as well.
58 and even my sister,
59 they attacked her in the bathroom as well,
60 and they hit her,
61 and they left her there
62 my sister too had just arrived
63 she had been here 11 months
64 Anna: and what happened why did they-
65 Katia: for no reason
66 just for being Latina I think,

(Story follows)

Let us first examine lines 1–40, which constitute an argumentative sequence leading to the telling of Katia's narrative. At the beginning of the extract, Katia is trying to explain and seemingly justify the fact that she learned English slowly at school; she offers as a potential explanation her belonging to a particular group of friends (lines 3–4). However, the causal relation between group belonging and English learning is not made explicit and the reaction of the interlocutor (i.e. asking for an explanation, line 5) reframes Katia's statement into a position needing support. And indeed, Katia starts her next turn with an utterance introduced by the connectors *porque* and *como* ('because' and 'since'), indicating a casual relation between the propositions conveyed in them and the initial position that she learned slowly because of her friendship group. In this response to her interlocutor's 'why' question (lines 6–7), she states that she did not speak English and that her school was very 'diverse'. However, there is no clear explanation here of how these two factors related to her self-described slow rate of English learning. Instead, Katia provides details about her school in order to make her reasoning clearer to her interviewer. She describes what 'diversity' meant at her school: that groups were divided along ethnic/racial lines with little interaction among them (lines 9–17). This division is conveyed and underscored also through enumeration and repetition of the same structure (e.g. 'the whites had their white group of white kids', 'the African Americans had their group', lines 9–10). Note also how Katia contrasts between types of intergroup relations by opposing Asians and Anglo-Saxons as groups that sometimes mixed with each other on the one hand, and African Americans and Latinos who are qualified as 'totally different' (in lines 14–15) on the other. Lines 16–17 provide further support to the position that there was no mixing between these groups. And in general, all these descriptive statements by Katia justify her reported choice to side with the Latino group. Indeed, her utterance in line 18 ('I felt more identified with the Latino kids that had just arrived from the different countries') is preceded by 'then' (*entonces*), a marker indicating a relation of cause/consequence between the division among groups and her identification with the Latinos. In turn, her Latino group membership – in conjunction with the fact that only Spanish was spoken by that group – is proposed by Katia as the reason for her slow learning of English (line 21). Thus, the answer to her interlocutor's question of 'why' her

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learning of English was slowed down by her friendships (line 5) appears only after a sequence of utterances that propose a series of cause/consequence relations. We summarize her argument in the following paraphrase:

> *Initial position*: My group of friends made it more difficult for me to learn English.
> *Explanations*: A. Because I didn't speak English and B. My school was diverse.
> *Explanation of B*: Diversity meant that each group remained separate.
> *Cause–Consequence*: (Since I had to choose groups) I identified with the Latinos.
> *Cause–Consequence*: Since the Latinos only spoke Spanish, I learned English slowly.

The next sequence of utterances contains the main position that prompts the telling of Katia's story. Her interlocutor asks for clarification about the language repertoire of the school groups and then about their relations (lines 22–6), and Katia states (line 27) that there was no relationship between the groups. Concomitantly, she also begins to position herself as not responsible for this lack of interaction (e.g. in line 28 'and that was one of the things that made me feel strange') and to position others as having much greater agency in the creation of this conflict (e.g. lines 36–7 'they were not very friendly'). Notice that Katia starts building the case that there was discrimination, or at least that differences among the groups dominated the atmosphere (see line 33, where she substitutes the word 'difference' for the word 'discrimination'), but implies a lack of responsibility on her part although not a total lack of agency. Indeed, she uses the impersonal and non-committal pronoun 'one' when she talks about feeling discriminated against (line 31) and when responding to a clarification question by the interlocutor who is trying to elicit further details about the discrimination. In her answer, Katia uses the impersonal 'one' in conjunction with modal verbs referring to attempts to make friends or break barriers ('maybe *one wanted* to have white friends' and 'there were limits to where *one could* get to', lines 36–8), but then becomes more agentive and uses the pronoun 'I' in a later utterance when she states that she could never make friends outside her group (line 38–9). These statements, which together form the proposition that the racial/ethnic boundaries in Katia's school were impermeable, constitute the basis for the next question by the interlocutor, which elicits a story as an exemplum. Indeed, the interviewer elicits the telling of a specific instance of the experiences that Katia has described in her previous turn. Thus, Katia's story is framed as an exemplum that supports her previous points.

Katia answers the interviewer's question in the affirmative, then seems to hesitate, and at last produces an attention-grabbing abstract that takes the interlocutors back to the issue of language learning proposed at the beginning of the exchange, while also intensifying audience interest (line 44). Katia's abstract is a typical story opening in that she says just enough to stimulate her interlocutor's interest and to give her interlocutor the opportunity to ratify her telling of the narrative. This is exactly what happens in the next turn (line 45) as the interviewer uses the repetition of her opening as a prompt for her to continue with the telling. Thus, the story proper initiates in line 46. In the orientation section, Katia introduces the antagonist who she describes as an African American girl, the place of the action (the school bathroom), and the circumstances (she was washing her hands and was alone) (lines 46–7). As highlighted in past work (De Fina, 2000, 2006), categorization, particularly in orientation sequences, is a powerful mechanism

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for identity construction in storytelling since it allows storytellers to project story-world actions as consequences of (or at least as related to) specific identities. In this case, the antagonist's African American identity is presented as consequential for the action to be described later and also as relevant to the preceding discussion of racially/ethnically defined school groups. In line 48, Katia introduces the complicating event: 'they harassed me and they told me ''You stink''". Notice that here the antagonist is no longer identified as an individual African American girl (as in the orientation); the pronominal reference has become plural: 'they'. Katia does not provide further details on the nature of the harassment, emphasizing the personal effect of not understanding the utterance that accompanied the aggression. Her reaction is described in psychological terms: the narrator as character is positioned not as 'doing' something, but simply as 'thinking', that is, as going over the answer of the African American girl in 'her mind' (49). The next complicating action presents the narrator asking another girl who spoke English about the meaning of that expression. So Katia uses reported speech (the explanation provided by her friend, line 50) as a story-world resolution and a conclusion of the narrative. Indeed, in the following line she returns to the abstract using it this time as a coda (line 54 'so that@ was the first word that I learned'). The following lines (55–60) constitute the external evaluation (that is the evaluation by the narrator, not by the characters) of the story and they are used to convey its significance and therefore to position Katia vis-a-vis the other characters. Again, she uses the impersonal pronoun 'one' to describe how this situation affected her ('one starts getting intimidated'), but also the first-person 'I' to stress her innocence vis-a-vis her antagonist (line 56, 'I was doing nothing to her'), and then uses the following evaluation lines as a form of legitimation of her use of the story as an exemplum, rather than an isolated incident. Indeed, in the final evaluation lines Katia gives further evidence about the fact that some friends and her own sister had received the same treatment. Thus, the events told in her narrative are presented as an exemplum, not as an individual incident. Here, she uses the same construction employed to describe her own experiences in line 48: they + active verb + object pronoun (lines 59–60 'they attacked her', 'they hit her'), where the stress is on the African American girls as active agents. In line 64, the interviewer inquires as to why she was hit and Katia's explanation makes the point about her own story clearer as she answers: 'For no reason, just for being Latina' (lines 65–6). The conversation continues with the telling of a second story.

Our analysis of the argumentative structure here highlights how the narrative functions both as an exemplum of the type of ethnic/racial divisions that characterized Katia's school and as further support for the fact that her slow learning of English was caused by that situation. Thus, Katia's story of personal language conflict is related here as an instance of ethnic/racial conflict. Indeed, inclusion of this narrative in the pool of language conflict stories could be questioned as Katia's conflict is not directly about language. It is not clear whether the African American girl (or girls) harassed Katia because she did not speak English or for some other reason. However, the narrator presents the two questions as so fundamentally entrenched that the narrative is emblematic of the way language competence and group identification are presented in other stories. Katia focuses the telling on the ethnic conflict in different ways. First, as we saw, her experiences are presented as instances of a group conflict that was generalized throughout the

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school. Second, the identity of the aggressors (the girls) is clearly signaled by her in terms of their ethnic/racial group membership. Third, their actions are characterized in terms of a pattern of repeated episodes. This presentation illustrates the operation of the linguistic mechanisms that Sacks (1966/1992) called 'membership categorization devices', that is, the categorizations through which behavior and actions are presented as typical of a social identity category. In this case, aggressive behavior is presented as typically carried out by African Americans. At the same time, Katia's positioning in the storytelling world is passive. We have seen that she does not attribute any agency or responsibility to herself, and in many ways she presents her choice of siding with one group (the Latinos) as a consequence of the racial and ethnic divisions, not as a real choice. However, she also conveys the message that she did not agree with such sharp divisions and that she would have preferred to break them (e.g. she implies that she was trying to make friends with whites, lines 38–9). She morally positions herself in the storytelling world as a person who is both non-aggressive and tolerant. Thus, through her story Katia both reflects and contests some of the broader ideological currents and discourses outlined above and therefore constructs her positioning vis-a-vis such wider constructs. For instance, in accordance with mainstream language ideologies, learning English is presented as her individual responsibility, and her lack of English competence is framed not only as central to this particular incident, but as something which warrants justification. At the same time, Spanish is vilified as the source of her personal problems and as socially divisive within the school. Katia also reflects the social categorization of people into previously established ethnic groups and reflects shared and widely spread conceptions about ethnic hierarchies and group relations. In particular, she emphasizes the idea that Asians are closer to 'Anglo Saxons' than African Americans and Hispanics (see De Fina, 2006 on ideologies about hierarchies of color) and confirms the existence of conflict between those two communities. However, Katia's story world and her positioning within that world also signal her resistance to these divisions and discourses and her adherence to – or possibly a desire for – a more egalitarian moral order.

From an interactional perspective, there is little co-construction with the interlocutor, who does not intervene in the telling other than to ask questions or clarifications. However, such lack of intervention also implies shared – or at least unchallenged – ideological presuppositions with the interviewee. With respect to narrative structure, unlike other language conflict narratives in the corpus, this story has a Labovian, canonical organization and the conflict is well defined and described (although not well developed). In other language conflict narratives, the complicating event and the development of the action are not clearly delineated as the narrators seem more focused on illustrating a thesis about inter-group relations than on the details of the experience. However, as evident below, group conflict is usually clearly present and is developed along similar lines.

To illustrate these points, we analyze next a second narrative told by Elisa (Excerpt 2) in response to a direct question by the researcher. Elisa had worked as an undocumented nanny and cleaning person in various private homes in the DC area for more than 12 years. Here, she relates an experience where her lack of competence in English had been a source of conflict with other 'people' (line 1). In the talk preceding the fragment transcribed below, the interviewer had been inquiring as to whether Elisa agreed with the English language requirement for US citizenship. Elisa had explained that she did not

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agree because many people do not know how to speak English. It was at this point that the interviewer asked about language conflicts:

Excerpt 2

1	Ken:	y has tenido algún conflicto acá con, entre gente por no hablar inglés o
2		entre gente que solo habla-
3		alguien te ha dicho una vez tienes que hablar inglés o algo así?
4	Elisa:	en Virginia,
5		cuando fui a dejar un din- el din- dinero de la oh hace dos meses atrás,
6		estuve en el bus y había una señora que hablaba no sé que me dijo en
7		inglés no?
8		y yo no le contestaba porque,
9		y hay una persona que habla una chica, que habla español e inglés
10		me dijo "te está riñendo porque eres latina" me dijo,
11		"y estas son todas esas personas que son son de ahí del lado de Virginia de
12		Arlington no? de ese sector que están discriminando a los latinos".
13	Ken:	uhu.
14	Elisa:	porque yo estaba sentada adelante y ella estaba atrás,
15		dice que yo le tapaba con mi cabeza su cara y que no quería
16		eso era,
17		yo no le había entendido no?
18		y entonces yo sentada "pues que me importa que me estará diciendo" dije
19		yo.
20	Ken:	oh!@@
21	Elisa:	yo no le estaba dando motivo@ y entonces dice
22		y la otra dice: "está riñéndote eso es"
23		y yo le dije "ah que ni y y que le estoy haciendo a esta señora" yo le
24		dije?
25		"en ese [bus" dice ella "va a todas riñendo,
26	Ken:	[uhm
27	Elisa:	son dos viejas que siempre están yendo en el bus
28		y cuando se topan con alguna latina que no le cae y andan riñendo
29		no?"
30	Ken:	y qué estaba diciendo?
31	Elisa:	diciendo que no se qué vaya a otro lado a sentarse->
32		y que no se siente allí a su a su delante->
33	Ken:	oh!
34	Elisa:	sí así.
35	Ken:	wow!

English translation

1	Ken:	and have you had any conflict here with, among people for not speaking
2		English or people who only speak-

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has anybody told you once you have to speak English or anything like
that?
Elisa: in Virginia,
when I went to leave some mon- mon- money of the oh two months ago,
I was on the bus and there was a lady that was saying I don't know what
she said to me in English, you know?
and I was not answering because,
and there is a person who speaks, a girl who speaks Spanish and English,
she told me "she is fighting with you because you are Latina" she said
"and these are all those people there on the side of Virginia from
Arlington you know? from that area that are discriminating against
Latinos".
Ken: uhu.
Elisa: because I was sitting in front and she was sitting behind,
she says that my head was getting in her way, and she didn't want it
that was it
and I had not understood, right?
so I was sitting and "what do I care about whatever she is telling me"
I said.
Ken: oh!@@
Elisa: I was giving her no reason@ and so she says
and the other one says: "she is scolding you that's it".
and I told her "so what and what am I doing to this lady" I told
her?
"in this [bus" she says "she is scolding all the women
Ken: [Uhm
Elisa: these are two old ladies that are always in the bus
and when they come across a Latina that they don't like they start
fighting right?"
Ken: and what was she saying?
Elisa: saying I don't know what go sit somewhere else->
and not to sit in front of her ->
Ken: oh!
Elisa: yes, like that.
Ken: wow!

Elisa's narrative, like Katia's, is elicited by the interviewer. But in this case it is the interviewer who frames lack of English as a potential source of conflict, even suggesting a scenario where people would have openly scolded Elisa for not speaking English (lines 1–4). Elisa readily acknowledges that she has had those experiences (line 5). In the story orientation, she specifies the event location (in Virginia, a detail that later will prove important), the circumstances (she was going to deposit money), the place (the bus), and the first complicating event: a lady said something to her in English that she didn't understand and therefore she did not answer (lines 6–8). As she is starting to provide an explanation for her lack of response Elisa self-corrects and introduces a new story-figure: 'a

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girl who speaks Spanish and English'. The narrator uses the girl's voice to position Elisa's antagonist in the story world, as the girl provides an interpretation of the antagonist's intention rather than a translation of what the lady had said. In the girl's voice, the lady is presented as an aggressive character who is acting out of prejudice; she is characterized as 'fighting', and the real motive for fighting is attributed not to Elisa's actions, but to her identity as a 'Latina'. As in Katia's story, the language problem is immediately related by the narrator (through the voice of another character) to hostility among ethnic groups. But while in Katia's narrative arguments about interethnic group relations were the source of the telling, here the argumentative links between causes and consequence are made by characters within the story world. Thus, Elisa uses the bilingual girl to explain those connections. Indeed, she continues by creating a casual link between the antagonist's behavior and her identity as a member of a social group. Such membership is signaled (lines 12–14) through the attribution of the action of discriminating against 'Latinos' to 'all those people there on the side of Virginia'. In this way, the antagonist is presented not only as acting wrongly, but also as behaving in a manner that is typical of the social group with which she is identified. Importantly, this characterization presupposes shared perceptions with the interviewer of Virginia as anti-immigrant in light of recent state and county approvals of restrictive immigration laws[2] that led to high-profile operations targeting undocumented workers and denying community services.[3] Thus, what appears to be a 'geographical' characterization of the antagonist is in fact a categorization of the woman in terms of her belonging to anti-immigrant groups.

After an acknowledgment of understanding by the interviewer (line 15), Elisa continues with a series of evaluation clauses that provide an explanation of what had happened in the complicating action. Here, again the antagonist is presented as unreasonable as she is described as 'annoyed' because Elisa had not reacted to her protests that she was 'sitting with her head in her way' (lines 17 and 18), grounds for annoyance that would appear trivial or nonsensical to most people. In the following lines, the narrator positions herself in the story world as both defiant and innocent. On the one hand, she uses reported speech to present herself as consciously ignoring the lady (lines 20–21: 'so I was sitting and "what do I care about whatever she is telling me" I said'), but on the other hand, she justifies her lack of engagement by underlining her innocence (line 23: 'I was giving her no reason'). Reported speech is used again at this point, but here in the form of a dialogue between the two 'positive' characters, Elisa and the bilingual girl, who stress the same interpretation of the conflict that had already been proposed at the beginning of the story. In the dialogue, the bilingual girl repeats her explanation of the lady's intentions of 'scolding' Elisa (line 24); Elisa also re-emphasizes her innocence in her response (lines 25–6: 'so what and what am I doing to this lady?'); and this time, the bilingual girl proposes a new explanation of the antagonist's behavior. The girl attributes the scolding to two old women (presumably the antagonist and a companion), but she also voices the reasons for their behavior in more negative terms as they are depicted as initiators of the fights and as targeting Latina women 'that they do not like'. Both characterizations describe the antagonists as aggressive and prejudiced since their dislike for Latina women appears to lack any concrete motivations (lines 27–30). At this point, the interviewer asks a clarification question inquiring as to what had been the words of the antagonist (line 32), and Elisa responds with a reconstruction whose accuracy she qualifies as

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uncertain (she premises with 'I don't know what'), according to which she was told to sit somewhere else (lines 33–4). The quotation elicits the interviewer's moral indignation (signaled by discourse markers 'oh' and 'wow' indexing surprise and disbelief; lines 35 and 37), indicating that the antagonist has been successfully positioned as completely unreasonable and prejudiced.

To summarize, in this narrative Elisa uses reported speech by another character (the bilingual girl) to present an interpretation of the conflict that causally links the aggressive behavior of a person presented as a member of an out-group to Elisa's identity as Latina. She employs the same strategy together with lexical choice (in particular the attribution of actions such as 'scolding' and 'fighting' to the lady in the bus) to position her antagonist as aggressive and unreasonable. But Elisa also elicits a reaction of moral indignation through her emphasis on the racially or ethnically prejudicial nature of her antagonist's actions. At the interactional level, Elisa projects an identity as a person who is capable of fighting injustice and of proposing a different moral order. There is also greater co-construction between interviewer and interviewee here with respect to Katia's story, since the interviewer initially frames language difficulties as language conflicts and participates in the expression of moral indignation.

As in Katia's story, we also see here evidence of how broader ideologies and discourses about language and ethnicity are reproduced but also contested, and therefore of how Katia positions herself with respect to them. While the interviewer focuses her question on English-language conflict, Elisa responds with a story in which lack of English is an excuse for ethnic conflict. Since she proposes an interpretation of the action of her antagonist that is based on group membership, she does not question the correspondence between language competence and ethnic identity implied in mainstream language ideologies. However, Elisa does resist the negative positioning that such ideologies perpetrate against Latinos as a group and Spanish as a language.

In these two narratives, attributions of responsibility and characterizations about membership differ: in the first, ethnic or racial descriptions are applied to protagonists, and in the second, to the antagonists. However, in both stories the language conflict (real or imagined) is only the manifestation of another kind of (wider) conflict in the discourse of interviewers and interviewees as well as in the story worlds constructed in the interviews: that is, conflict between groups whose ethnic or racial identity is a determining factor. This is reflected in story-structures; in both stories, there are few complicating-action clauses and the majority of clauses are evaluation or orientation clauses, indicating the lack of stress on actual story action. Further, in neither conflict story is language really a central point of contention. In the first, Katia's inability to speak English could have been a trigger for the harassment, but this is not clear from the complicating event. In the second, the conflict is even more ambiguous as it is not clear whether the fight started because Elisa could not understand what the lady said and therefore did not react 'appropriately', or if the fight was independent of her (in)comprehension. The lack of clarity in the depiction of the complicating events is both a result of the narrators-as-characters' confusion about what they were being told (in English), and of the stress that they place on the in-group/out-group conflict that leads to a greater insistence on the ethnic or racial conflict in general terms rather than on the circumstances of its origination within particular events.

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These narratives can be productively compared with narratives of language difficulties. In these, language is presented as a problem between individuals, not groups. This contrast is evident in the following narrative (Excerpt 3) by Serena, a woman from Bolivia working as a nanny. Because of space limitations, we do not provide a detailed analysis of this narrative here, but only highlight the differences in how the narrator frames language problems. Here, Serena is telling (at the beginning of the interview) how she felt in the period immediately after her arrival in the US and commenting on her dependence on her employer to move around the city:

Excerpt 3

1	Serena:	me sentí coja manca sorda por el idioma,
2		entonces y como verá ((name of employer)) empezó a gestar,
3		ella estaba en cama porque el embarazo de ella, era bastante complicado
4		no?
5		entonces prácticamente ella no podía ayudarme a mi,
6		digamos,
7		acompañarme a salir o a conocer los malls ni nada->
8		tuve que empezar sola.
9		entonces yo me recuerdo que el primer domingo que salí
10		yo no sabia hablar inglés y me dieron un,
11		de ese tamaño coca cola llenito de hielo
12		y la verdad que no quería hielo porque en esa fecha es mucho frío,
13		entonces bueno fueron cosas que yo experimenté ya y-
14	Anna:	le dieron una coca cola y usted no podía explicarle que no quería
15		hielo o?
16	Serena:	yo yo le dije coca cola pero no o supongo que el hombre me preguntó
17		"chico o grande" y co- entonces le dije "Coca cola" y me dieron una así
18		grandota,
19		y y me dijo "tanto tanto debes",
20		entonces yo le pasé la plata,
21		me dijo "no, falta"
22		entonces yo le pasé otra vez y cosas así.
23		entonces yo decía "qué hago!"
24		y, por cierto yo guardé el vaso de coca cola@@
25		y lo man- llevé a Bolivia y le digo@ y @ "mira lo que me han dado!"
26		y mis hermanos se mataban de la-
27		porque fue la primera experiencia porque no podía decirles que no,
28		yo quería un vaso de coca cola pero más- más chico @que este no esta así
29		todo salía así y supongo que ellos pedían pero a mi me dio igual y yo
30		pensé que era normal,
31		entonces cuando yo llegué a la casa les explique qué- qué había pasado y
32		me dijo "seguro que te preguntaron el small large o medio",
33		pero yo no le entendí no- no sabia sólo le dije: "yo quiero coca cola" y me
34		dieron eso.

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35 Anna: uhu.
36 Serena: y son cosas que- que pasan.
37 una vez también quedé encerrada en el metro,
((SECOND STORY))

English translation

1 Serena: I felt as if I had no arms I was lame and deaf because of the language,
2 so and since you see ((name of employer)) got pregnant,
3 she was in bed because her pregnancy, was rather complicated
4 you know?
5 then practically she could not help me,
6 let's say,
7 take me out to see the malls or anything,
8 I had to start alone->
9 then I remember that the first Sunday that I went out,
10 I did not know how to speak English and they gave me
11 this size a coke full of ice,
12 and the truth is that I did not want the ice because it was very cold then,
13 so well those were things that I experienced and and-
14 Anna: they gave you a coke and you could not explain that you did not
15 want ice or?
16 Serena: no I told him coca cola but no or I suppose that the man asked me
17 "big or small" and co- so I told him "Coca cola" and they gave me one
18 really big,
19 and he told me "you owe that much",
20 so I gave him the money,
21 he told me "no, it's not enough",
22 so I gave it to him again and things like that,
23 so I was wondering "what should I do!"
24 and, actually I kept the coke cup @@
25 and sent- took it to Bolivia and I said@ and @ "look what they gave me!"
26 and my brothers were killing themselves with la-
27 because it was my first experience and I could not say no,
28 I wanted a coke but more- smaller @than that not like that,
29 everything that was given was like that and I suppose that they asked but
30 I did not care and I thought it was normal,
31 so when I got home I told them ((her employers)) what happened and
32 she told me "they surely asked you small large or medium",
33 but I did not understand- I did not know and I only said "I want coca cola"
34 and they gave me that.
35 Anna: uhu.
36 Serena: and these are things that happen.
37 once I got stuck in the underground.
((SECOND STORY))

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Through this narrative, Serena reconstructs a memory of when she had to go out alone for the first time because her employer was confined to pregnancy bed rest. She introduces the narrative by emphasizing how she felt handicapped by her limited English proficiency (line 1) and then by recounting the circumstances that had led her to go out alone (lines 2–7). In line 8, the story begins. The complicating event is constituted by Serena's request for a Coke, which came in a big cup full of ice (lines 9–13) because she did not know how to ask for a small one. Here, the interviewer solicits a clarification, and Serena reports the dialogue with the vendor: how she had asked for a Coke, how the vendor must have asked her what size she wanted it without her understanding, how she got the large Coke (lines 16–17), the sequence involving the payment (lines 19–22), her own dismay at the size of the Coke (line 23), and the humorous conclusion: she kept the cup to show its size to her brothers in Bolivia who were amused by it (lines 24–6). Then there is a further explanation of the episode (lines 27–30) and a return to the story action when Serena recounts how she told her employer what had happened and received an explanation from her (lines 31–4). Serena concludes with a coda, 'these are things that happen' (line 36), that functions as a device to diminish the potential 'drama' of the events told and that also opens the way for another story.

The emphasis in Serena's story is on the experience of being unable to communicate. Serena does not comment on racial, ethnic, or geographic identities: the seller is simply *el hombre* ('the man'), and the lack of English competence is not source for confrontation or prejudice. The story evaluation is presented in humorous terms, with the brothers laughing at the size of the Coke or, more generally, at silly things that can happen in a new place. All of the language problem narratives are similar to this one in that they describe specific circumstances and individuals who are seen as unique. In contrast, language conflict narratives most commonly convey an evaluation of an antagonist seen as a member of an out-group.

4. Conclusion: Immigrant narratives, identities and language ideologies

This discussion of Latin American immigrant women's narratives examined how language conflicts are depicted and negotiated in interaction through an analysis of narrators' argumentation both within and outside the story world, and of positioning devices such as word and pronoun choice and reported speech. We have illustrated some of the connections across the way conflicts are presented (and received); the identities that narrators (and interviewers) claim relevant to these conflicts; and the language ideologies that are widely circulated in connection with the use of Spanish and English, particularly within discourses about migration. We have seen that, in the interviewers' questions (and follow-ups) and in the interviewees' language conflict narratives, there is a clear tendency to both confirm and reproduce central aspects of the language ideologies that dominate discourses about migration. The language conflict narratives analyzed here illustrate not only how Spanish is problematized and racialized through stories about everyday experiences, but also how language comes to represent a major obstacle for (certain) intergroup relationships in the US. Further, these language conflict narratives

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demonstrate how the way languages are viewed is to a large extent an integral part of what Bourdieu called 'habitus' (1990): that is, the system of presuppositions about social reality and relations, based on past experiences but constituted in practice, that is taken as conventional wisdom and unlikely to undergo critical scrutiny.

Hispanics have recently overtaken Blacks as the group most believed to be the target of discrimination, with one in four Americans reporting that Hispanics face 'a lot' of discrimination (Pew Hispanic, 2010b). Further, one-third of Latinos (age 16 or older) report that they, a family member, or a close friend have experienced ethnic or racial discrimination in the previous five years (Pew Hispanic, 2010b). The conflict narratives analyzed here illustrate one of the processes through which everyday experiences are racialized as well as one of the mechanisms through which discourses on race and ethnicity are constructed and circulated.

Concomitantly, these narratives can also be seen as forms of resistance. The narrators are individuals whose social positions have been profoundly damaged by such ideologies, independent of the accuracy or credibility of the individual incidents they report. Through these language conflict stories, narrators contest their marginalized social and linguistic position, both in the story world and in the real world. In fact, these stories, and the discourse in which they are embedded, illustrate the effects of everyday life in a context dominated by an antagonistic ideology in which speaking English or Spanish aligns one with one group or another based on dominant membership categories. These women's narratives are in great part the result of these broader conflicts. One can only hope that a different kind of discourse might soon gain currency – one in which those who speak a language other than English can regain and retain their dignity as individuals.

Notes

1. Spanish is the second most spoken language in the US after English, with 31 million speakers and a growth of 62 percent of Spanish-speaking population between 1990 and 2000 (US Census, 2004).
2. See, for example, http://leg1.state.va.us/cgi-bin/legp504.exe?000+coh+2.2-4311.1+704875
3. See http://www.freerepublic.com/focus/f-news/1865112/posts

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Transcript conventions

.	at the end of words marks falling intonation
,	at the end of words marks slight rising intonation
!	animated tone, not necessarily an exclamation
(.)	micro-pause
[	overlapping speech
(( ))	transcriber's comment
->	continuing intonation as in lists
@	laughter
-	self or other interruption
?	rising intonation in clause
::	elongated sound
" "	reported speech

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